

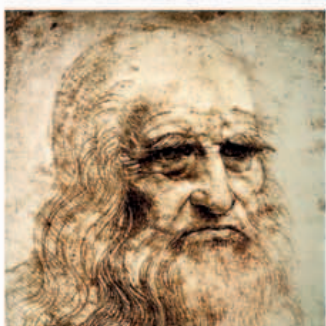


This map by Alberto Cantino was the first to show Portugal's discoveries in the West and East and the division between Spanish and Portuguese territories agreed upon at Tordesillas.

IN 1494, POPE ALEXANDER VI drew up the **Treaty of Tordesillas**, which effectively divided up existing and future New World discoveries between **Spain and Portugal**. It drew a north–south line 370 leagues (about 1,350 miles or 2,000 km) west of the Cape Verde Islands. Land to the west was assigned to Spain; that to the east, to Portugal.

The political crisis provoked in Florence by the **death of Lorenzo ("the Magnificent") de Medici** in 1492 was exploited by a Dominican monk, **Girolamo Savonarola**, who imposed on the city a "Christian and religious republic." In 1494, he denounced tyrants and instituted the **Bonfire of the Vanities**: the destruction of idolatrous goods. He was overthrown, tortured, and executed four years later.

The **Italian Wars**, nominally sparked by the desire of Charles VIII of France (1470–98) to **assert a claim** to the kingdom of Naples, saw an intermittent **65-year struggle** between France and Spain for control of Italy. Its opening salvo, which ended in 1499, was both destructive and inconclusive. The first phase ended with the **Battle of Fornovo**, fought



LEONARDO DA VINCI
(1452–1519)

Born in Italy, Leonardo was a self-taught polymath—a painter, sculptor, inventor, and scientific enquirer—whose restless genius drove him to embrace a limitless range of projects, but to complete almost none. Among his masterpieces are *Mona Lisa* and *The Last Supper*. He died in France in the service of Francois I.

near Parma in July 1495. However, having made his triumphant way to Naples to claim its throne, Charles VIII found his former Italian allies, notably Milan, had joined forces

with Venice, the papacy, and the Holy Roman Empire to oppose him in a **Holy League**, ending his dreams of Italian conquest.

By about 1496, an outbreak of what was commonly called the **French pox** (so-named as it was first recorded among French troops there) occurred in Italy. It was syphilis. By the middle of the 16th century, about **one million people** had contracted the disease—probably from a more virulent strain brought by **sailors returning from the New World**.

From about 1490, **Genoese mariner** John Cabot had lobbied Portugal and Spain to sponsor a westward voyage to Asia across the Atlantic, but was rebuffed. He turned his attentions to England, basing himself in Bristol. An early voyage failed, but in May 1497—with royal backing—he set out again. He **reached northern Newfoundland**, then sailed south along 400 miles (650 km) of coast. He returned to England certain he had reached China. The following year, he led a much larger expedition. All but one of its five ships were lost, Cabot with them. But his initial success prompted five more voyages to **Newfoundland** from 1501 to 1505, which confirmed the new discoveries were clearly not Asian. Despite these disappointments, the English ventures were important in proving the existence of a hitherto unsuspected continent—**North America**—and in staking a claim to later English primacy in its exploration and settlement.



This 20th-century painting depicts King Manuel I of Portugal blessing Vasco da Gama and his expedition as they get ready to set sail from Lisbon.

THE SOUTHWARD PROBING ALONG the African coast by the Portuguese in the 15th century had reached a climax when **Bartolomeu Dias** rounded the tip of Africa in 1488. In May 1498, **Vasco da Gama** consolidated this achievement when he continued into the Indian Ocean and reached

Calicut in southwest India. A practical **route to the East** had **been discovered**. Da Gama's crossing of the Indian Ocean—crisscrossed by Arab and other trade routes since the 9th century—depended on local Muslim knowledge. His route to the Indian Ocean, on the other hand, was new. Where previous Portuguese mariners had hugged the African coast, da Gama made a vast sweep **westward into the South Atlantic**. It was not only the longest ocean crossing yet made,

Battle of Zonchio

This woodcut depicts ships in the first battle of the Ottoman–Venetian War. It was the first time cannons had been used in a naval battle.



1,000,000

THE APPROXIMATE NUMBER OF
**EUROPEANS WHO CONTRACTED
SYPHILIS IN 50 YEARS FROM 1496**

